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Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Section Title(S)

Kusazvibata • Kutuka (To Scold or Insult) • Makuwa (Harmful Gossip)

Courage can also be expressed by simply using the word *murume*, which denotes that the person is a man and so has courage the opposite of a woman. Any male who lacked courage was looked down upon even to the extent of being called *murume pasina varume* ('a man where there are no other men' which is a polite way of saying that he is a woman among other men').

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Kutuka (To Scold or Insult)

Scolding is a serious offence, and every boy and girl is warned against using insulting words against anyone. Insulting language is often heard at beer-drinks. Women, too, scold one another when one borrows a pot or utensil from the other. If the article is not returned, insulting language may follow. A man is liable to become furious if he is insulted in derogatory terms. There is, however, a special type of scolding among ritual friends which takes the form of a joke and is not taken seriously.

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Makuwa (Harmful Gossip)

Makuwa or detraction of a person's character is practised in private through an individual spreading a falsehood by gossip. *Makuwa* is more often

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indulged in by women in their huts. It involves spoiling a person's name or damaging his reputation, but although it is said in private the information spreads and sooner or later reaches the ears of the victim, when quarrelling and fighting not uncommonly ensues. When the Shona employ *makuwa* they imply both detraction and falsehood (calumny). Thus any derogatory statement to a Shona is *makuwa*. On the other hand when the detraction or falsehood is made public the term *kuparidzira mosva yo mumwe yakavanda* is used. For instance a person may declare publicly that a certain man is having an affair with someone's wife. This sort of statement is likely to end in court. It is said however that *kuparidzira* only came with the missionaries, who wanted to draw a distinction between calumny and detraction.

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I think the point is made that in Shona society the aim is a high moral code. It must also be conceded that these people have  63 a good concept of what is right and wrong, what is decent and what is likely to upset another.

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